DEEPSTACK
The Buildout · Part 09 · Memo

AGENTIC COMMERCE

Habit Was the Moat. Agents Are Draining It.

Meta's Muse has inserted itself between shoppers and sellers. The first bill is coming due for businesses paid by customer inertia.

By DeepStack · October 3, 2026 · Agents · 8 min read on the page · deepstack.ltd/stories/habit-was-the-moat/

THE DEEPSTACK CALL

Split **Sell habit, buy the rails**

Agents will drain weak consumer habits first. Back the rails (trust, records, distribution, compute), not the forgotten subscription.

Conviction Moderate (3/5) · Version 2 · Oct 9, 2026

WHAT TO DO WITH THIS

1. Flag businesses that live on inertia: forgotten subscriptions, commodity brands, ad-funded marketplaces.
2. Favor owners of trust, regulation, systems of record, distribution and compute.
3. Judge agent launches on retained users, transactions and fees, never on downloads.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE OUR MIND

- Meta reports agent downloads without retained users, transaction volume or fees.
- The first tax season with agents shows households still paying Intuit for certainty.

THE FULL ARGUMENT

The direction is clear even if the timing is not: agents will pressure weak consumer habits before they replace durable software or the companies that own the rails. The single most important reason is economic position. Muse is not merely answering; it is choosing, paying and deciding which seller is seen. That makes forgotten subscriptions, commodity brands and ad-funded marketplaces vulnerable, while trust, regulation, system-of-record status, distribution and compute remain defensible. We would change our mind if Meta reports downloads without retained users, transaction volume or fees, or if the first tax season shows customers choosing agents over Intuit's certainty. Until then, the stock moves are an early invoice, not a finished income statement.

CALL HISTORY

Version	Date	Stance	Conviction	Reason	By
v2	Oct 9, 2026	Sell habit, buy the rails	Moderate (3/5)	Side named by the owner.	Marco Cauduro
v1	Oct 3, 2026	Sell habit, buy the rails	Moderate (3/5)	First call, as published with the story. The conviction, the actions and the flips were set down for the site on October 7, 2026.	DeepStack

BY THE NUMBERS

18%
Meta stock gain
Closing prices, Financial Modeling Prep, Sep 8-Oct 2, 2026

33%
AMD stock gain
Closing prices, Financial Modeling Prep, Sep 8-Oct 2, 2026

3%
Paid consumer AI adoption
Moses Sternstein, first quarter estimate

61%-70%
Booking in AI recommendations
Oguz Erkan, September 2026

WHO IS ON EACH SIDE

How fast do habits break?

Each voice is attributed and paraphrased, dated where the date is known, with a link where one exists. DeepStack shows no score, ranking or accuracy for any person. The page: `deepstack.ltd/sides/habit-was-the-moat/`

6 VOICES

Eighteen months, or less

Andrew Walker Sep 28, 2026
Faced with two extreme camps on consumer AI agents (that they are massively overhyped versus that every consumer-facing company is a short because agents will eat their margins), Andrew Walker says both are too extreme but if forced to pick, they...
`www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/before-you-fade-muse-use-it-for-72`

Andrew Walker Sep 21, 2026
AI agents make price-shopping and replacing skilled workers (e.g., using AI to edit a podcast instead of a consultant) easy, and if saving money is the core consumer use case for AI, this could have a deflationary impact on the consumer economy at...
`www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/if-muse-is-buying-your-running-shoes`

Tae Kim Sep 7, 2026
As computer tool use rises, AI compute demand will explode just as it did when agentic coding took off, when reasoning models ramped, and when AI chatbots were first released.

Tae Kim Sep 22, 2026
Having used Muse over the past week, Tae Kim found problems in the quality and accuracy of its responses and found it hard to choose it over ChatGPT, and suspects others will feel the same way.
`taekim.substack.com/p/metas-muse-is-no-sure-thing`

Ren Sep 25, 2026
Once an AI moves from surfacing a link to researching, deciding, executing and paying, it inserts itself between the customer and the business, potentially capturing an unusually valuable piece of the internet's discovery and transaction funnel.
`renstocks.substack.com/p/meta-muse-ai-is-done-answering-questions`

Ren Sep 25, 2026
The unit of interaction is shifting from the prompt to the objective: instead of a chatbot loop of question-and-answer, Muse takes a goal, plans, executes, and only interrupts the user at decisions it isn't allowed to make alone.
`renstocks.substack.com/p/meta-muse-ai-is-done-answering-questions`

THE STRONGEST CASE AGAINST THIS SIDE

Le Shrub Sep 22, 2026

Le Shrub questions whether Meta's Muse AI agent becoming popular so quickly is a big negative for OpenAI and Anthropic.

Contradicts Andrew Walker on evidence · www.shrubstack.com/p/uncomfortable-truths

6 VOICES

Still a demo

Moses Sternstein Sep 18, 2026

The data suggests that, for now, the story is 'App-Slop': AI has produced many more apps, but they are not successful apps in any meaningful sense.

www.a16z.news/p/charts-of-the-week-so-many-apps-so

Moses Sternstein Sep 18, 2026

Paid consumer AI adoption remains quite low even though it is growing, per Consumer Edge data showing roughly 3% adoption as of Q1, with younger people adopting at about 4x the rate of older people.

www.a16z.news/p/charts-of-the-week-so-many-apps-so

David George Sep 28, 2026

The creators argue OpenAI will prevail not because of best models, chips, cost-performance curve or even best product — though they think OpenAI has those — but because it is so good at creating new kinds of customers and has the most durable...

www.a16z.news/p/openai-understands-something-important

David George Sep 28, 2026

As of September 2026, the creators say intelligence-as-a-service product rankings are no longer the most important question; intelligence is everywhere and nearly anyone can do nearly anything, yet most people aren't yet, so awakening new behavior...

www.a16z.news/p/openai-understands-something-important

Michael Spencer Sep 29, 2026

Michael Spencer is not confident about Muse's odds of success, citing that only Anthropic has shown how to scale ARR so far in this Generative AI cycle, that the ratio of app downloads to actual users seems fairly low and suspicious, and that Meta...

www.ai-supremacy.com/p/the-era-of-personal-super-intelligent-agents-muse-2026

Michael Spencer Sep 8, 2026

Generative AI's impact on the macro economy and labor market is a serious concern: higher inflation, less hiring, more anxiety, and a lack of ROI compared to the debt, capex and resulting AI bubble, with higher earnings masking dangerous...

www.ai-supremacy.com/p/gpt-6-astra-hugging-face-incident-2026-review

THE STRONGEST CASE AGAINST THIS SIDE

Le Shrub Sep 22, 2026

Le Shrub says that, like an everyday 'normie', they want something simple and non-geeky for daily tasks rather than a highly advanced model that solves difficult math problems, implying simpler consumer AI tools like Muse may win out over more...

Contradicts Michael Spencer on evidence · www.shrubstack.com/p/uncomfortable-truths

3 VOICES

Voices that cross sides

Andrew Walker Sep 28, 2026

Andrew Walker says they cannot watch how easy Muse is to use and how fast its downloads have taken off and conclude it won't have a big impact on the consumer economy.

www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/before-you-fade-muse-use-it-for-72

Andrew Walker Sep 28, 2026

Andrew Walker suggests that Muse acting as a layer that decides where consumer spend goes is a massive threat and opportunity for retailers, noting as evidence that Amazon banned Muse.

www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/before-you-fade-muse-use-it-for-72

Tae Kim

On the owner of the agent and on the rails beneath it.

taekim.substack.com/p/metas-muse-is-no-sure-thing

ALSO IN DISPUTE

Whose margin pays?

8 VOICES

The inertia businesses

Andrew Walker Sep 11, 2026

Craneware's customer base of established US hospitals is likely highly resistant to replacing entrenched software systems, making the business unlikely to be disrupted by AI coding tools.

www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/uk-stocks-are-dirt-cheap-why-wont

Andrew Walker Sep 21, 2026

The major current use case for consumer AI agents appears to be saving people money, as illustrated by widely retweeted examples of an agent called Muse saving users money on insurance, returns, phone bills, and even getting free food.

www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/if-muse-is-buying-your-running-shoes

Torsten Slok Sep 29, 2026

Either tech's customers will generate a lot more cash than their analysts expect, or tech's cash flow forecasts are too optimistic, which raises the question of who exactly will be writing all those checks to buy AI services.

www.apollo.com/insights-news/insights/daily-spark/tech-trillion-dollar-internal-inconsistency

Torsten Slok Sep 27, 2026

Agentic AI assistants like Muse could soon automatically sweep household cash into accounts paying 3.3% to 5.0%, instead of leaving it in checking accounts earning the 0.1% national average.

www.apollo.com/insights-news/insights/daily-spark/is-an-agentic-bank-run-coming

Tae Kim Sep 22, 2026

Despite Muse's initial traction, its long-term success is far from assured; Meta can cross-promote it across Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp, but competitors with similar distribution advantages are coming, with OpenAI likely being the biggest...

taekim.substack.com/p/metas-muse-is-no-sure-thing

Tae Kim Oct 2, 2026

Tae Kim says he has seen enough: the personal AI agents released over the past month will be a huge paradigm shift for computer usage and a major positive inflection point for technology.

taekim.substack.com/p/openais-undeniable-resurgence-and

Alex Immerman Sep 29, 2026

Customers already accept higher menu prices on DoorDash to pay for convenience, which was necessary for restaurant economics to work; Alex Immerman is uncertain whether people would similarly accept higher prices shown to assistants or pay a...

www.a16z.news/p/who-gets-paid-when-ai-does-the-shopping

Alex Immerman Sep 29, 2026

AI assistants don't need to replicate Amazon's warehouses to pressure Amazon's profits; they only need to become the place where the customer decides what to buy, illustrated by Amazon banning Muse while Shopify, which lacks a comparable scaled ad...

www.a16z.news/p/who-gets-paid-when-ai-does-the-shopping

THE STRONGEST CASE AGAINST THIS SIDE

Abhi Yadav Sep 27, 2026

Enterprises face a bind between building AI tools (which may never get past pilot) and buying vendor platforms (which risks more organizational intelligence ending up inside somebody else's system).

Qualifies Andrew Walker on condition · abhiyadav.substack.com/p/ownership-isnt-building-it-yourself

6 VOICES

Not every habit

Oguz Erkan Sep 13, 2026

Booking's competitive position in its core market is currently unshakable because its global, differentiated network reinforces supply-side lock-in, which in turn reinforces demand growth; a dissatisfied hotel cannot find a distribution channel as...

www.capitalist-letters.com/p/booking-holdings-deep-dive-an-attractive

Oguz Erkan Sep 13, 2026

Google Search is declining but the decline is concentrated in informational rather than transactional queries; citing Ahrefs and Pew, Oguz Erkan says transactional-intent query share grew from 24.7% in 2025 to 26.4% in 2026, and Booking gets 61-70%...

www.capitalist-letters.com/p/booking-holdings-deep-dive-an-attractive

Andrew Walker Sep 24, 2026

Andrew Walker's market-related takeaway is that Muse (a consumer AI agent) is very bearish for businesses that rely on consumer inertia (OTAs, subscription services, banks, etc.), and the stock market seems to be starting to agree with and catch up...

www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/musings-on-muse-the-inertia-sell

Andrew Walker Sep 24, 2026

Based on conversations with 'normie' friends (a possibly small/early sample), most people who get access to Muse, including Andrew Walker himself, have an early productivity burst that fades off hard as usage falls off a cliff within a few days.

www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/musings-on-muse-the-inertia-sell

Invest in Assets Sep 10, 2026

The 'AI will replace TurboTax' narrative undersells how much of Intuit's moat is trust, compliance complexity, and habit rather than just software, and that gap between fear and reality is the opportunity.

www.investinassets.net/p/fintwits-best-stock-ideas

Invest in Assets Sep 10, 2026

The narrative that AI will replace tax software is starting to crack because consumers and enterprises pay for certainty, and AI mistakes could be more costly than using software like TurboTax.

www.investinassets.net/p/fintwits-best-stock-ideas

ALSO IN DISPUTE

Who collects?

8 VOICES

The owner of the agent

David George Sep 30, 2026

As of April, barely about 2% of US households were paying for some AI service; the number is higher now and growing, but still tiny in the big scheme of things.

www.a16z.news/p/state-of-markets-ii

David George Sep 30, 2026

While nearly 30% of S&P 500 companies report some quantifiable impact of AI, only about 2% report any tracked metric, and similarly only a tiny share of the overall userbase is meaningfully deploying agentic use-cases at scale.

www.a16z.news/p/state-of-markets-ii

Mia Silverio Sep 21, 2026

Muse is gaining traction: as of that Friday it ranked No. 1 in Apple's App Store ahead of ChatGPT at No. 2, Gemini at No. 8, and Claude at No. 13, and since its September 8 unveiling Meta has added nearly $170 billion in market cap and is up 9%...

www.profgmedia.com/p/a-new-ai-app-beat-chatgpt-to-no-1

Mia Silverio Sep 21, 2026

Meta's Muse, released with less initial fanfare than the Anthropic-OpenAI race, is a serious AI agent product designed to handle everyday tasks like reservations, appointments, and purchases, with Meta's CEO stating the plan is to eventually take a...

www.profgmedia.com/p/a-new-ai-app-beat-chatgpt-to-no-1

Tae Kim Oct 2, 2026

After personally using OpenAI's Dots, Meta's Muse and Instinct, Tae Kim says he now has much higher confidence that personal AI agents will be the future of computing and a lift off for a new AI wave, praising how they proactively ping him about...

taekim.substack.com/p/openais-undeniable-resurgence-and

Tae Kim Sep 7, 2026

With the release of GPT-6 Astra, computer tool use AI has finally become real, and he is now confident AI will soon perform actual software knowledge work tasks better and faster than most humans, with competence accelerating rapidly from here.

Michael Spencer Sep 29, 2026

Since Meta Muse optimizes how consumers clean up digital subscriptions they no longer care about, at scale it could implode subscriptions and accelerate subscription fatigue further in 2027, significantly hurting independent media providers such as...

www.ai-supremacy.com/p/the-era-of-personal-super-intelligent-agents-muse-2026

Michael Spencer Sep 14, 2026

Michael Spencer is not sure a future AI monopoly warning about human-extinction risk will be well received given how unpopular AI and Silicon Valley currently are in America, Europe and elsewhere, and says more will be known once there is more data...

6 VOICES

The rails and the atoms

Alex Immerman

Shopify, Toast and Square get paid whichever agent brings the order.

www.a16z.news/p/who-gets-paid-when-ai-does-the-shopping

The VC Corner Oct 1, 2026

This is the first liability answer in agentic commerce that anyone has actually priced, and because merchants and consumers route toward whoever carries the risk, the default rail will be the one that pays for its own mistakes.

www.thevccorner.com/p/ant-international-amp-agentic-commerce-agentsafepay

The VC Corner Oct 1, 2026

The industry's central question is no longer whether the agentic economy will arrive but who will build the rails it runs on, and Ant International has made its bid to be that builder.

www.thevccorner.com/p/ant-international-amp-agentic-commerce-agentsafepay

Tae Kim

The CPU under every agent's machine.

taekim.substack.com/p/metas-muse-is-no-sure-thing

Stephen Clapham Sep 13, 2026

Stephen Clapham notes the FT panel did not explain the post-2022 fall in the graduate premium, and argues part of it is non-graduate pay rising rather than graduates faring worse, citing rocketing US demand for electricians, while judging AI too...

behindthebalancesheet.substack.com/p/when-the-numbers-dont-add-up

Stephen Clapham Sep 13, 2026

Moritz argued that AI is the inshoring of jobs to robots and tokens, threatening white-collar work as globalisation offshored blue-collar work, and that because each successive tech wave has reached more computers the effects will be felt more...

behindthebalancesheet.substack.com/p/when-the-numbers-dont-add-up

THE STRONGEST CASE AGAINST THIS SIDE

Jensen Huang Sep 15, 2026

Huang argues past dramatic AI predictions have proven wrong: a prediction that radiology would be completely taken over by AI within five years with no radiologists left turned out to be the opposite, since more radiologists are needed than ever; a...

Contradicts Stephen Clapham on evidence · taekim.substack.com/p/jensen-huang-on-the-irresponsible

NOT A DISAGREEMENT

The software split: same squeeze, three readings

Dead money (Eisman): $256B of software buyouts in 2021, up to 64% debt. Moats AI cannot erode (Market Sentiment, Dominguez): data, distribution, system of record. From the seat to the outcome (Folloni, Yadav): paid per resolved ticket, not per seat.

WHERE THEY CROSS

The specific points where one voice meets another: the same evidence read two ways, or the same mechanism with a different sign.

Moses Sternstein qualifies David George on mechanism

Tae Kim qualifies David George on evidence

David George qualifies Tae Kim on evidence

Stephen Clapham contradicts Tae Kim on evidence

Stephen Clapham contradicts Andrew Walker on evidence

Tae Kim contradicts Stephen Clapham on mechanism

Alex Immerman qualifies Ren on condition

THE DATED TESTS

What would settle it, on the Docket. A test is specified when an outsider can settle it without asking anyone: the question, the source, the rule and what happens if the source is late, revised or silent.

Oct 28, 2026 `p09-t01` PENDING

Meta reports its September quarter; users, transaction volume and fees would show whether downloads are becoming a business.

Question	Did Meta's September-quarter release, slides or earnings call state a number of users, a transaction volume or a fee revenue for Muse, beyond download or install counts?
Source	Meta investor relations, third-quarter 2026 results `investor.atmeta.com/`
Rule	Read the release, the slides and the call transcript on Meta's investor-relations site. The answer is yes if they state a count of monthly or weekly Muse users, a transaction volume, or a figure for fee revenue or recurring revenue from Muse; no if they give download or install counts alone, or no Muse figure.
If the source is late, revised or silent	If Meta reports after November 30, 2026, or restates the quarter, the test is inconclusive, and the Result says what was read and what was missing.

Nov 3, 2026 `p09-t02` PENDING

Booking reports room nights and direct mix; the result tests whether the agent or the incumbent owns the booking.

Question	Did Booking Holdings report September-quarter room nights above the September quarter of 2025, with a direct-channel share of bookings no lower than the share it reported a year earlier?
Source	Booking Holdings investor relations, third-quarter 2026 results `ir.bookingholdings.com/`
Rule	Read room nights and the direct mix from the release and the call. The answer is yes if room nights are above the year-earlier quarter and the direct share is at or above the year-earlier share; no if either declined.
If the source is late, revised or silent	If Booking gives no direct-mix figure for the quarter, or reports after November 30, 2026, the test is inconclusive, and the Result says what was read and what was missing.

Nov 16, 2026 `p09-t03` PENDING

Nike holds its investor day; margin targets and demand plans show how much selling still assumes human choice.

Question	Did Nike, in the materials published for its investor day of November 16 and 17, 2026, state a numerical operating-margin or gross-margin target for a fiscal year beyond fiscal 2027?
Source	Nike investor relations, investor day presentation and press release `investors.nike.com/`
Rule	The answer is yes if the presentation, press release or webcast transcript on Nike's investor-relations site states a margin target with a number and a fiscal year beyond 2027; no otherwise. How much of the demand plan still assumes a person choosing (stores, app, wholesale, marketing) is DeepStack's reading from the same materials and goes in the Result, not in the answer.
If the source is late, revised or silent	If the investor day is postponed past November 30, 2026, or the materials are not public, the test is inconclusive, and the Result says what was read and what was missing.

Jan 1, 2027 `p09-t04` PENDING

The first tax season with agents tests whether households still pay Intuit for certainty or ask an agent.

Specification pending

Amazon standoff p09-t05 PENDING

Amazon allowing agent checkout would show the advertising pool beginning to move; continued resistance shows its value remains protected.

Specification pending

THE TEST CAME IN

No test from this Part has resolved yet. Results are promoted by a person and listed on the Results page.

SOURCES AND FURTHER READING

1. Reuters - Meta launches Muse · www.reuters.com/business/meta-launches-ai-agent-that-can-access-other-apps-send-emails-make-payments-2026-09-08/
2. CNBC - Amazon blocks Muse · www.cnbc.com/2026/10/03/meta-muse-shopping-ai-agent.html
3. 24/7 Wall St. - enterprise repricing · 247wallst.com/investing/2026/09/28/meta-and-servicenow-drop-4-as-enterprise-platform-launch-reprices-software-mongodb-tumbles-19/
4. Apollo - technology cash-flow question · www.apollo.com/insights-news/insights/daily-spark/tech-trillion-dollar-internal-inconsistency
5. a16z - AI shopping economics · www.a16z.news/p/who-gets-paid-when-ai-does-the-shopping
6. Yet Another Value Blog - Muse test · www.yetanothervalueblog.com/p/before-you-fade-muse-use-it-for-72
7. Capitalist Letters - Booking analysis · www.capitalist-letters.com/p/booking-holdings-deep-dive-an-attractive
8. Market Sentiment - software moats · www.marketsentiment.co/p/the-next-great-ai-trade-is-everything
9. Invest in Assets - Intuit moat · www.investinassets.net/p/fintwits-best-stock-ideas
10. Prof G Markets - Muse market value · www.profgmedia.com/p/a-new-ai-app-beat-chatgpt-to-no-1
11. The VC Corner - agentic payments · www.thevccorner.com/p/ant-international-amp-agentic-commerce-agentsafepay
12. Fiscal.ai - Ennismore software moat · fiscal.ai/fund-letters/ennismore-fund-management-q3-2026-fscl_document_7GJK2WQN204

How DeepStack settles a question

Every Part of The Buildout asks one question and gathers the strongest case on each side from named investors and analysts, attributed, dated and linked. DeepStack then takes a side in The DeepStack Call, names what it would take to change its mind, and sets dated tests that an outsider can read on the day. When a test comes in, the result is published with its evidence, confirmed, refuted or inconclusive, and the Call's history records when the house changed its mind and why. No person is scored or ranked. No accuracy rate is shown until ten results exist.

Quoted passages are short, attributed by name and linked to their source; the paraphrases are DeepStack's. Quote this memo with attribution and a link to the canonical page.

This memo reflects the page as of October 12, 2026. Canonical page: https://deepstack.ltd/stories/habit-was-the-moat/. Who is on each side: https://deepstack.ltd/sides/habit-was-the-moat/.

Analysis and opinion, not investment advice.